

Japanese Government Expands Medical Waste Intervention in Enugu Through New Incinerator Project

The Government of Japan, through its Embassy in Nigeria, is deepening its health interventions in Enugu State with plans to install a medical waste incinerator at Abakpa Health Centre. The incinerator will serve the health center along with over 20 public and private health facilities within Enugu East Local Government Area.

This major initiative is being funded by the Embassy of Japan in Nigeria Grassroots Human Security Project (GGP), and implemented by South Saharan Social Development Organisation (SSDO). The project aims to address long-standing challenges with hazardous waste disposal, improve infection control, and enhance the overall quality of healthcare service delivery in the state.

A delegation from the Embassy of Japan in Nigeria, led by GGP Coordinators Wakana Deguchi and Kenechukwu Adibe, visited Enugu. Accompanied by the leadership of SSDO, headed by Dr. Stanley Ilechukwu, the delegation visited the proposed project site and engaged with key health stakeholders. The visit began with a meeting with the Enugu State Commissioner for Health, Dr. Emmanuel Ikechukwu Obi, and was attended by Dr. Ifeyinwa Ani-Osheku, Executive Secretary of the Enugu State Primary Healthcare Development Agency, and Prof. Uche Agu, Hospital Administrator of the Enugu State Health Management Board.



All three officials lauded the proposed incinerator project and pledged their full support, noting its significance in relieving health facilities of the burden of transporting waste over long distances to the state's cold store for incineration.

Leading the site tour at Abakpa Health Centre, Dr. Ani-Osheku explained that the choice of location was informed by the facility's central position, its high patient volume, and its proximity to dozens of other healthcare centres that could benefit from the project. The incinerator will offer both public and private facilities a safe, local, and cost-effective option for waste disposal, with a token-based access model under consideration.



The team also toured Poly General Hospital, where SSDO and the Embassy of Japan previously implemented a 56KVa solar power project under a GGP grant awarded in 2020. That solar installation, which includes 96 solar panels, was completed in 2021 and continues to power the hospital independently of public electricity, ensuring uninterrupted care delivery.



Speaking on the broader context of the current intervention, Udochukwu Egwim, SSDO's Head of Programmes, noted that the organisation had conducted a thorough needs assessment across multiple facilities. While solar power had been considered again, the pressing need for effective waste management infrastructure made the incinerator a more impactful choice.

“Each facility was struggling with how to safely dispose of waste,” Egwim said. “Rather than duplicating our previous work, we identified the need for a waste incineration hub. Abakpa emerged as the ideal location.”

This initiative represents a model for sustainable health partnerships, blending international cooperation with local expertise to deliver targeted, lasting solutions to real problems.

